A skald composing in tenth-century Iceland and an engineer at Bell Labs in 1950 were working on the same problem, and they reached the same answer: structure is redundancy, and redundancy is how a signal survives a channel that wants to corrupt it. One worked in kennings, alliteration, and meter. The other worked in parity bits.

The skald's channel was human memory, a poem carried intact across centuries of imperfect recall; the engineer's was a noisy wire. Same fight against loss, different substrate. The skalds were only one workshop among many: the scribes who counted every letter of the Hebrew Bible, the reciters who kept the Vedas word-perfect for three thousand years — whole information technologies built to hold knowledge against forgetting, corruption, and forgery.

Now a machine writes with perfect fluency and no idea when its own memory has invented something, while the field rediscovers these old defenses one patch at a time. If **Gödel, Escher, Bach** and **Hackers & Painters** are on your shelf, you have felt this convergence coming. The question the book leaves you turning over: what can the information technologies of the ancient world teach modern AI?

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What the Viking Poets Knew

David Walther

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That AI Researchers Need To

The beauty of the baud,
the poetry of the process



David Walther